The Four Varnas

We now come to the *Varnas*, or the fourfold classification of society into the *Brāhmanas*, the *Ksatriyas*, the *Vaiśyas*, and the *Śūdras*. The real significance of the classification does not lie in the historical fact of its being propounded by the Hindus of India more than twenty centuries ago, or its being practiced today in the extremely outdated form of the caste system. It lies in the fact that the Hindus evolved a structure of an ideal society, which must always include these four classes distinguished on the basis of their merits, qualifications, and functions. It is further contended by the Hindus that any society even today has these four classes. First, the elite or the learned, the wise or the leaders, the policy-makers, the lawgivers, the legislators are called today by the name of the rulers or the administrators. Second is the class of the defenders of the faith of the society called the military. They do not have to be either learned or wise as do the rulers. As fighters for the faith whenever it is in danger, they must only follow the policies and the dictates of the rulers. Third is the large class of traders, businessmen or merchants whose function is to produce and distribute consumer goods and wealth to the community and the people. Last, we have the largest class of people in the society who are not the rulers, the military men, or the business magnates, but are simply workers, laborers, wage earners. These correspond today to the Hindu *Varnas*, only we do not prescribe the same qualifications for their functions. But there are these four classes, *Brāhmanas*, *Ksatriyas*, *Vaiśyas*, and *Śūdras*. No society can work satisfactorily without the coordination of these four classes. Never will a society have only one or two classes as the Communists believe. The only difference between the Hindu classification of an ideal social structure and today's classification lies perhaps in the qualifications and duties of the *Brāhmanas*, or the good and wise men, who are the rulers of the society. This Hindu classification is not at all undemocratic when it is remembered that democracy does not mean that everyone is equally fit to be a *Brāhmin*. Originally this classification was based strictly on qualifications and merit and not on birth or heredity. As the centuries passed, classes based on occupations multiplied into hundreds, and, as occupation in olden times was based on heredity, the institution gave rise to the present caste system in Hindu society. As beggary is the evil legacy of the Hindu doctrine of the four *Āśramas* and gives the highest place in society to the begging *Sanyāsin*, the caste system is the legacy of the ideal fourfold classification of